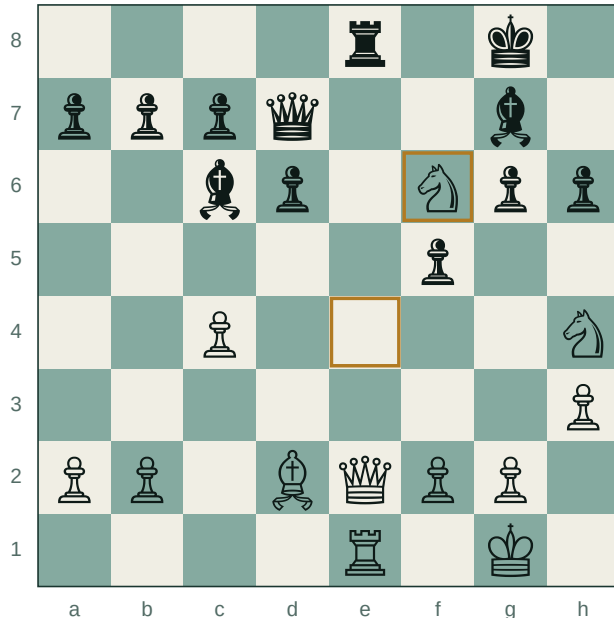


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 24

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 24.Nf6+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

24...Bxf6 25. Qxe8+ Qxe8 26. Rxe8+ Bxe8

24...Bxf6 The bishop captures the knight on f6. Recorded reply: **25.Qxe8+**.

25...Qxe8 The queen captures the queen on e8. Recorded reply: **26.Rxe8+**.

26...Bxe8 The bishop captures the rook on e8.

At the end, nominal material is White 12 / Black 13 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -2 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: knight on f6 and knight on h4. Check for tactical protection.